09 PODCAST STUDIO THE LAPIS ROOM

A blue room with a wall of books you can hear: home of the Astralab podcast.

LEVEL	CREW	WHERE	STAGE NOW
■□□ Open to all	1–3	Yusuf's current bedroom	Book drive + book wall

Yusuf's bedroom becomes the Lapis Room: blue-accented, home to the Astralab podcast. One wall is built from chopped hardback books. It looks extraordinary, and the uneven depth of the books scatters sound the way a studio diffuser does, so the room sounds better too. A Murphy bed comes later.

FIRST STEPS *today*

1. Measure the room: every wall, the ceiling height, windows and doors. Sketch it.
2. With Yusuf, decide where the Murphy bed goes, so the book wall is planned around it.
3. Set up a cutting station: a saw, a clamp jig set to the cut depth, a bin for the page offcuts (they go to the compost or the hens' bedding).
4. Cut and glue a single 2 × 4 ft test panel to see the look before committing a whole wall.
5. Help run the book drive (below).

BEFORE YOU START

- Cutting books on a bandsaw or table saw: clamp the book, use a push block, keep fingers out of the blade's line. Only cut with a saw you've been shown.
- Old books carry dust and mold spores. Wear a mask when cutting.
- A Murphy bed must be anchored to solid framing. Check the wall can take it before building around it.

THE BASICS

The book wall — Cut each hardback parallel to the spine, keeping the spine and 2–3 in of pages. Glue (construction adhesive) and screw the book blocks onto ¾ in plywood panels in rows; screw the panels to the studs. The wall stays removable.

Why it sounds good — Books of different depths break up sound reflections (diffusion). For absorption, add a few DIY panels: wooden frames filled with wool or mineral wool, wrapped in blue linen, placed beside and behind where people sit. A rug and heavy curtains do a lot.

Mics for a real room — Dynamic mics reject room sound; condensers pick it up. Options (approx. prices): Samson Q2U (~$70), Rode PodMic USB (~$200), Shure MV7+ (~$280), Shure SM7B (~$400).

Recorder — Zoom PodTrak P4 (~$200): records 4 mics to an SD card on batteries. Good for a solar-powered room. Rodecaster Duo (~$500) for a fuller setup.

Furniture — A solid desk wide enough for two people facing each other 3–4 ft apart. Boom arms (or floor stands) so desk knocks don't reach the mics. A guest chair that is silent: no squeaky swivel, no creaking leather.

Blue, traditionally — Ultramarine was first made from lapis lazuli. Limewash tinted with ultramarine pigment gives the deepest, most natural blue. Gold accents nod to the pyrite in lapis.

HOW-TO NOTES

The call for books	Post on Hira's Instagram: hardbacks wanted, cloth and blue spines especially welcome. Use a drop-off point in town (a friend's shop) so the land's address stays private. Write each donor's name inside their book. Other sources: Friends of the Library book sales, library discards, thrift stores that sell books by the pound.
Murphy bed	Most vertical queen Murphy beds need about 7½ ft of clear ceiling height; confirm with the kit's spec. DIY hardware kits (spring or piston mechanisms) let you build the cabinet yourself, e.g. Rockler.
Power + noise	A podcast setup draws little power. Listen for hum from the inverter or other appliances and keep audio gear on one circuit.

THE PLAN *in order*

01	**Measure + sketch**	Room plan; Murphy bed location fixed.
02	**Book drive**	Instagram call, drop-off point, collection.
03	**Book wall**	Cutting station, test panel, then full panels mounted.
04	**Acoustics**	Absorption panels in blue linen, rug, curtains.
05	**Studio**	Desk, boom arms, mics, recorder, headphones, guest chair.
06	**Color**	Ultramarine limewash accents, gold details.
07	**Murphy bed**	Hardware kit, cabinet built and anchored.

TOOLS & MATERIALS

- Bandsaw or table saw, clamps, push block
- Construction adhesive, screws
- ¾ in plywood panels
- Stud finder, drill, level
- Wool or mineral wool, linen, staple gun
- Dust masks

FOR YUSUF TO DECIDE

- ? Murphy bed position
- ? Which wall(s) get books
- ? Mic and recorder choice
- ? Desk and guest chair
- ? How much blue

Resources: Murphy bed hardware kits: Rockler (rockler.com)